Vendor Strategy & Partner Management

Do not just select a vendor.
Select a partner who can stand with the business when it matters.

Fit | SLA | Governance | Lock-in

Session purpose

Evaluate

vendors and partners

Protect

business outcomes

Govern

delivery, cost, risk

Vendor strategy is a leadership decision

Cloud transformation is delivered through an ecosystem — not by technology alone.

Ecosystem

- providers
- SIs
- SaaS
- MSPs
- advisors

Price is not the only lens

Choosing a vendor only by low price is like choosing a surgeon by discount.

Message

cost matters

capability matters more

Opening power question

When selecting a partner, what matters most?

Cost

Capability

Trust

SLA

Flexibility

Session journey

1. Why vendor strategy
2. Vendor types
3. Evaluation criteria
4. SLAs + governance
5. Framework exercise

Why vendor strategy matters

Vendors influence

architecture
cost
security
operations

Poor choices create

lock-in
hidden cost
unclear accountability

Strong choices create

reliability
innovation
business value

Not a procurement event

Vendor selection is a strategic partnership decision.

Test

promise + delivery capability

Cloud partner ecosystem

1. Cloud provider
2. System integrator
3. SaaS vendor
4. Managed services
5. Advisory partner

Vendor type 1 | Cloud service providers

Maturity

Security

Roadmap

Vendor type 2 | System integrators

Design
architecture

Migrate
legacy systems

Integrate
ERP + data + apps

Vendor type 3 | SaaS vendors

Product fit

does it meet process need?

Adoption

will users actually use it?

Limits

customization + data ownership

Vendor types 4–5 | MSPs and advisors

Managed services

operate
monitor
optimize
respond

Advisory partners

strategy
governance
roadmap
change

Ecosystem humour

One vendor sells it,
one implements it,
one runs it,
and one explains

why they are not aligned.

Message

governance connects the ecosystem

Vendor evaluation criteria

1. Business fit
2. Capability
3. Security
4. Integration
5. Cost transparency
6. Support

Criterion 1 | Business fit

Understands context

diversified enterprise

Speaks business

not only technology

Connects outcomes

value + KPI

Criterion 2 | Technical capability

- Architecture
- Migration
- Security design
- Data + AI

Criterion 3 | Industry experience

Similar problems

case studies

Enterprise scale

large programs

Regulated contexts

audit + control

Criterion 4 | Security and compliance

Certifications
security posture

Incident process
response readiness

Audit support
evidence + reporting

Criterion 5 | Integration capability

- ERP
- CRM
- Finance
- Plant

Criterion 6 | Cost transparency

Proposal price

only the beginning

Hidden cost

support, renewal, exits

TCO view

full lifecycle cost

Criterion 7 | Delivery governance

Milestones

clear progress

Escalation

before crisis

Quality

testing + assurance

Criterion 8 | Support and operations

Will the partner stand with us after go-live?

Look for

monitoring
incident handling
escalation

Criterion 9 | Innovation capability

Roadmap

AI + analytics

Automation

Criterion 10 | Cultural fit

Transparency
tell the truth early

Ownership
solve, not blame

Pressure test
works during crisis

Vendor presentation humour

Every vendor looks excellent in a PowerPoint deck.

Real test

after the purchase order

Vendor evaluation scorecard

Business fit | 15%

Capability | 15%

Security | 15%

Integration | 10%

Cost | 10%

Support | 10%

Suggested Evaluation Dimensions

Evaluation Area	Weightage
Business fit	15%
Technical capability	15%
Security and compliance	15%
Integration capability	10%
Cost transparency	10%
Delivery governance	10%
Support and operations	10%
Innovation capability	10%
Cultural fit	5%

Scoring method

1

1 Weak

2

2 Below

3

3 Acceptable

4

4 Strong

5

5 Excellent

Scoring Method

Score	Meaning
1	Weak
2	Below expectation
3	Acceptable
4	Strong
5	Excellent

SLA is business protection

An SLA is not a legal formality.

It is an accountability mechanism.

SLA areas leaders should review

1. Availability
2. Response
3. Resolution
4. Escalation
5. Recovery
6. Audit support

SLA humour

SLA should not be like terms and conditions everyone accepts without reading.

When it matters

during outage
during audit
during exit

SLA pitfalls

Fast response

slow resolution

Hidden exclusions

fine print risk

Weak penalties

comfort on paper

Vendor governance model

Operational
weekly
tickets + incidents

Tactical
monthly
SLA + cost + risk

Strategic
quarterly
roadmap + value

Governance humour

Vendor governance should not be like visiting a doctor only when the patient is in ICU.

Vendor lock-in

Lock-in is not always bad.
Unconscious lock-in is.

Ask

is dependency intentional?

can we exit?

Reduce lock-in risk

1. Data portability
2. Open APIs
3. Exit clauses
4. Documentation
5. Internal capability
6. Review dependency

Build vs buy vs partner

Build

strategic

unique capability

Buy

standard

fast value

Partner

specialized

scale + speed

Vendor evaluation exercise

Evaluate the vendor using business fit, capability, risk, commercial clarity, and exit flexibility.

Exercise flow

1. Understand proposal
2. Evaluate fit
3. Score risk
4. Review lock-in
5. Recommend

Session close

The best vendor is not the one with the best pitch.
It is the one with the best fit, governance, and accountability.

Capability built

vendor decision capability
SLA awareness
lock-in thinking

Thank You

Let’s continue the cloud, AI and digital transformation journey.

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Empowering leaders to make smarter cloud, AI and digital transformation decisions.